

The Roles and Responsibilities of the Sales Manager

Roles and Responsibilities of the Sales Manager

The WDH Sales Manager is responsible for meeting revenue, profit and market share targets for the organisation:

- Setting Sales KPIs/Targets
- Monitoring Performance against KPIs
- Setting Commercial Terms and Incentives
- Managing Sales Team Performance

Setting sales KPIs/targets

- Work with each member of the sales teams to set sales goals
- Aggregate sales teams goals into targets for the company
- Identify growth customers for the coming period
- Ensure targets meet management's expectations in consideration of market conditions and competitive situation
- Define territories and responsibilities to ensure efficient operations including best use of sales staff

KPIs/Targets include: Revenue, Units, ASP, number of Sales Visits and cost of sales.

Targets to be broken down both by customer and by product family.

The process should be finalised before the company's budget is submitted to headquarters (August) and before each product launch.

Monitoring performance against KPIs

- Ensure sales team uses CRM correctly in line within company guidelines
- Ensure potential, unit target and visit target is entered in the CRM system before January deadline
- Analyse reports weekly/monthly/quarterly
- Conduct weekly One-2-One meetings with each member of the sales team to discuss performance, coach on actions and get feedback from the market
- Plan and lead monthly/quarterly sales meetings according to the Sales Meeting Charter
- Report sales performance to management

The Roles and Responsibilities of

Setting commercial terms and incentives

Actively monitor market conditions:

- Competitor's activities: including product launches, special offers, pricing, etc.
- Third party payers' activities: including reimbursement schemes

Actively monitor customers' activities:

- Marketing and advertising, buying patterns, plans for expanding, possibility of selling, etc.

Work with marketing and management staff to set commercial terms and sales incentives including:

- Pricing for products
- Customer discount schemes
- Customer incentives
- Launch offers
- Activity plans

Set up bonus schemes for sales staff and monitor. Bonus scheme to also include company and, if appropriate, WDH Goals, to ensure team work.

Managing sales team performance

- Recruit and train appropriate staff
- Facilitate training in use of CRM, BI, sales techniques and appropriate product knowledge
- Communicate company's goals
- Ensure each member of the sales team knows what is expected of them (KPIs), buy in and are motivated to achieve them
- Use coaching and ride along to continually improve and develop sales skills and behaviour of the sales team
- Support sales team in removing barriers to performance
- Ensure team is motivated to achieve goals through incentive packages
- Empower and motivate
- Develop talent and skills
- Give constructive and consistent feedback based on observations, both verbally and in writing
- Develop good working relationships with customers and other team members
- Agree on actions required to improve performance
- Annual performance appraisal
- Coach people up or out as appropriate

The Roles and Responsibilities of the Sales Rep

The Roles and Responsibilities of a Sales Rep

Roles

Professional. The Face of the brand:

- Building Trust with customers and patients
- Credible, reliable, consistent & fair
- Ability to uncover and LISTEN to customer needs
- Friend (only when necessary)

Audiological Expert & Product Expert:

- Solutions-oriented (vs. product-oriented)
- Facilitation skills/Training skills/Teaching skills /Presenting skills
- Ability to tailor each interaction

Business/Practice Consultant:

- Resourceful Expert
- Someone that can respectfully challenge their way of thinking
- Patient Advocate

Personal Traits:

- Results-oriented (vs. activity-oriented)
- Share best practices with colleagues
- Motivated and committed

Responsibilities

Sales Performance:

- Quota & ASP attainment.
- Timely completion of administrative tasks
- Continual selling skills training and development
- Customer satisfaction

Market/Territory knowledge:

- Knowledge of why customers are growing and how to maintain that growth
- Knowledge of why customers are declining and plans to stop the decline
- Targets for new growth
- Knowledge of the potential for each customer
- Know the decision-makers
- Knowledge of what the competitors are doing

The Roles and Responsibilities of a Sales Rep

Time management and preparation of visit:

- S.M.A.R.T. plan in place for each account and each visit
(Specific, Measurable, Attainable, Realistic and Time-bound)
- What will the customer do differently as a result of the visit?
- Planned visits logged into CRM system
- Awareness and utilisation of available resources

Feedback and intelligence:

- All visits promptly entered into CRM
- Key information communicated directly to appropriate stakeholders
- Share best practices with colleagues

Sales Meeting Charter

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Sales Meeting Charter

Preamble

- Sales meetings can take place on a regular basis, or for special occasions (e.g., Product launches)
- Participation is mandatory for all sales reps
- Good preparation is vital for the success of the meeting; measurable goals should be clearly defined
- Meetings should involve active participation of sales reps (not a "listen only" meeting)
- Meetings should include Sales Training/Role Plays
- Thorough follow-up, measuring KPIs and controlling are essential part of the process
- Constant development and improvement of the process should take place
- Meeting etiquette is to be observed: no emailing, mobiles off, etc.

Preparation of Sales Meeting

What	When	Who
Book future meetings with the mandatory participants well in advance send invitations, internal/external participants	> 3 months before	Sales Manager
Plan goal of meeting, topics to be covered, participants (Mktg, Trainers, etc.), type (presentation, working group, training)	2 months before	Sales Manager
Organisation: Logistics, meeting room, catering, issue agenda, timelines	1-2 months before	Sales Manager
Prepare and send out in advance as appropriate: Sales figures, analyses, presentations, role plays, etc.	1 week before	Sales Manager, Sales Controller

Sales Meeting Charter

During Sales Meeting

What	Tools, Systems	Who	Goals
Presentation and discussion of Sales Trends vs. Budget. Per Customer Group, Region, Product segments, focus products, etc. Follow-Up on activities agreed on last meeting.	Power Point, BI reports	Sales Manager, Sales Controller	Create a sense of the business situation
Reports from regions.	Power Point, BI reports	Sales Reps	Stimulate own region analysis by Sales Reps
New Products: presentation, discussion, hands-on training, argumentation flow, role plays.	Presentation	Audiology, Product Management	Thorough knowledge of new products. Harmonised presentation to customers
Marketing: presentation of current and new campaigns.	Power Point, any marketing Tool	Marketing Manager	Joint deployment of campaigns
Sales Training, role playing.	Any training tools	Internal/External Sales Trainer	Improve selling skills
Update on competitors (each sales rep has responsibility to report thoroughly about one competitor company), selling against.	Verbal report	Sales reps	Knowledge about competitors, appropriate reactions
Next Steps in Sales (Actions to be executed in the coming quarter).	Power Point	Sales Manager	All pulling in the same direction
Social/Team building activity (include other departments if appropriate and if time allows).	Any	All participants	Team Building

Sales Meeting Charter

After Sales Meeting

What	Tools, Systems	Who	What are we trying to achieve?
Send out Meeting Minutes and action list to all participants.	Email	Sales Manager, Sales Controller	Joint execution of actions agreed
Report relevant issues from Sales Meeting to Management Team.	Management Meeting Agenda	Sales Reps	Define appropriate actions
Include relevant action points (goals) in the quarterly goals of Sales Reps.	Quarterly Goals Database	Sales Manager, Sales Controller	Drive attention of Sales Reps on agreed goals
KPIs: track results of agreed actions.	BI reports	Sales Manager, Sales Controller	Ensure timely reaction if targets not met
Field Coaching.	Co-travel	Sales Manager	Execution of agreed actions

Business Cycle

3Q 5
Management

Purpose

The purpose of the Business Cycle is to create a shared sales management Modus Operandi across the WDH Sales Companies that supports commercial excellence.

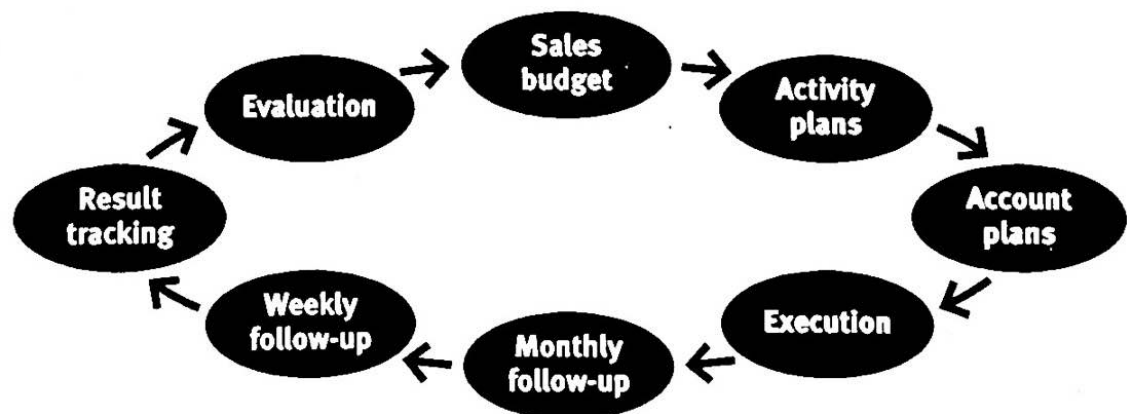
The Business Cycle aims at professionalising the overall annual business approach by securing a process involving:

- Analysing current sales situation
- Planning the most optimal use of sales, marketing, training and customer service resources
- Execution
- Sales management follow-up and eventual revision of plan
- Assessment and lessons learnt

Checklist – elements to cover

- Introduction to the Business Cycle
- Content of each step of the Business Cycle

Introduction to the Business Model



The Business Cycle describes how we plan, execute and follow-up within one business cycle, one fiscal year. The Business Cycle ensures:

- All sales activities are linked directly to business strategy, targets and activity/account plans
- Sales Management to follow-up on Sales
- Important lessons learnt are used to improve approaches and processes
- Effective Sales Coaching is conducted between Sales Rep and Sales Manager (and between Sales Manager and General Manager)

3Q Sales

Management Model

3Q Sales Management Model

Purpose

The purpose of 3Q Sales Management within the WDH group, is to have a common model/tool to drive sales and strengthen the sales management dialogue.

3Q Sales Management supports efforts towards setting objectives for and planning sales activities, prioritised towards the best potential, with the right approach and with the highest impact in the sales situation.

Checklist – elements to cover

- What is 3Q Sales Management?
- Where to use 3Q Sales Management?
- How to quantify 3Q objectives?
- How to improve Sales with 3Q?

What is 3Q Sales Management

3Q Sales Management defines the different elements of sales activities that lead to sales results:



Quantity

How many sales activities do we need to perform? Quantity of activities is crucial – basically, the more we do the higher the sales result.

Let us assume the sales rep is 5% behind sales budget (run-rate). There are still 4 months to catch-up and meet the annual sales budget objective.

In order to catch-up, the sales rep needs to alter his/her activity mix – the options are:

- **Quantity.** Increase number of visits. Be more visible in the marketplace
- **Quality.** Together with the Sales Manager, look for ways to improve how sales visits are conducted in order to increase the ratio of sales visits to sales
- **Qualification.** Change who to visit. See if there are any accounts on the ABC123 model where visits could improve sales – or identify the accounts where the increased quantity of sales visits should be distributed. Also consider if presenting other/new products to your existing accounts would help generate increased sales
- Ideally the Sales Rep and the Sales Manager should together look at a combination of all three activities. More quantity with no increased quality would be time consuming and unrewarding. Similarly, conducting only one visit per day, even if it is a quality visit, will not help you achieve your sales target goals

One-2-One

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Purpose

The purpose of the weekly One-2-One meeting is to support the sales rep in achieving the desired objective through a collaborative weekly approach.

- To coach in the 3Q Sales Management Model:
 - Quantity
 - Quantification
 - Quality
- To create an atmosphere that encourages focus on objectives and ensures success
- To develop sales reps through management by objectives

Content of the weekly One-2-One meeting

The content of the One-2-One meeting should reflect the following agenda:

- Since last One-2-One meeting incl. actions
- Result level:
 - No. of units sold last week
 - Revenue last week
 - Realised ASP
 - Reasons for deviations +/-
- Activity level: No of visits last week
 - Reasons for deviations +/-
- This week:
 - Result to be expected (units, revenue and ASP)
 - Visits planned
 - Reason for deviations +/-
 - Actions – need for change of sales activities re. 3Q
- Objection handling

Methods – result coaching

The leadership approach must relate to the level of the sales rep – the more experienced the sales rep is, the more important it is to have a more coaching approach (What do you propose...). If the sales rep is less experienced, the leadership style should be more direct and instructing (I have decided...).

Best Practice Execution

Timing

The weekly One-2-One meeting is best executed as a recurring Monday morning meeting of approximately 15 minutes. All One-2-One meetings must be completed before the sales manager has the consolidated One-2-One meeting.

The One-2-One can be held by telephone or by LYNC.

As a guideline 20% of the One-2-One should be focused on last week and 80% focused on this week.

KPI's

The data for the One-2-One are distributed to sales rep. and sales manager. The consolidated report is distributed to sales manager and general manager.

Field Based Coaching

Purpose

To continually improve and develop the skills and behaviour of the field sales team.

Scope

Customer visits.

Responsibilities

Sales Manager

- Ensure process is understood by Sales Representative
- Schedule appointments in advance confirming the purpose and role of your visit with the Sales Representative
- Provide constructive and consistent feedback post meeting (verbally) and after (writing)

Sales Representative

- Plan the day
- Provide Sales Manager with information prior to the event ensuring customer is fully informed
- Conduct Meeting
- Appropriate update of CRM
- Fulfil action plan

Procedure – before

Sales Representative	Sales Manager
	Confirm travel arrangements to assist the Sales Rep in planning the day.
	Clearly communicate any specific requirements e.g., type of appointment and any information (together with deadline) required for own preparation.
Plan the day suitably; • Meet/pick-up • Customer appointments • Drop-off	
Provide an outline of the day; • Schedule	
Provide for each scheduled visit; • Customer pen picture • Snapshot of business • Business objectives for visit • Expected outcome	
	Ensure that CRM is consistent with information provided from Sales Representative.

Procedure – during

Sales Representative	Sales Manager
Make introductions.	
	Thank customer and briefly confirm own role for that particular visit.
Conduct the meeting.	
	Observe & Note – with particular attention to; Course of meeting relative to objectives Use of sales tools/techniques • Prepare • Open • Ask • Present • Overcome • Close • Follow up • Filters • Active listening • Power of Questions • Power of silence
Close the meeting.	
	Thank the customer again.

Procedure – post meeting

Sales Representative	Sales Manager
	Invite dialogue about the meeting e.g., How did the Sales Representative think the meeting had gone?
Discuss the meeting; • Control of meeting? • Course of meeting? • Performance during meeting? • Were objectives met? • Was anything missed?	
	Provide feedback based on observations.
	Determine with Sales Representative what their action should be, and time scale or opportunity.

Procedure – after

Sales Representative	Sales Manager
Update CRM • Record of visit • Follow-up • Actions • Objectives for next visit	
	Confirm that CRM is consistent with the visit, follow-up, actions, and objectives for next visit.
	Follow up in writing to Sales Representative providing feedback consistent with that delivered post-meeting and confirming the agreed action/follow-up including timeframe or activity.
	Determine and schedule with Sales Representative the scheduled timeframe or date for next coaching session.
Acknowledge actions and timeframe and confirm suitable means for follow-up (e.g., phone call) with Sales Manager.	
Fulfil commitment to action • Customer perspective • Continuous improvement perspective	

Feedback form

Use the Feedback Form to note and give feedback.

Field Based Coaching Feedback	
Sales Representative :	
Sales Manager :	
Date :	
Customers Visited :	
General comments :	
Preparation	
Visit	
Follow-up specific	
CRM	
Actions & Time Frame	
Action(s)	When?
Sales Manager	
Sales Representative	

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SALES VISIT: Preparation

Purpose

The purpose of the preparation phase is to create the strongest platform possible for your sales visit. Remember, preparation is 90% of success!

Checklist – elements to cover

- Evaluate the KPIs of the customer. (Visits, units, revenue, run rate).
What is the current status of the customer?
- Evaluate the temperature of the relationship. How well do you know them, their staff and their business?
- Set SMART objectives for the visit – what is to be achieved?
Sales/Relationship/Product mix
- What will be your tactics? What will be your agenda?

Best Practice Execution

Evaluate the KPIs of the customer.

Evaluating the KPIs of the customer tells you quickly where to focus your meeting.

When did you last visit your customer?

What was the outcome? (Check your written minutes & notes in CRM)

What do you need to follow up on during the visit?

How many units have been sold?

What is the product mix now compared to your goal?

What needs to be introduced or challenged?

What is the status of revenue? On target/behind/ahead?

What needs to be adjusted in order to reach your revenue target (product mix, ASP)?

Where are the opportunities to improve Share of Wallet?

What is the current run rate?

Will you reach your target with this run rate or do you need to invent another approach to the customer?

What do you need to investigate with the customer in case of significant deviations from run rate? (Reasons, what to do, adjustments, etc.)

SALES VISIT:

Opening

Purpose

The purpose of the opening phase is to create trust in you and the brand you represent, and to establish an atmosphere of openness, which you will benefit highly from in the coming phases of the sales visit.

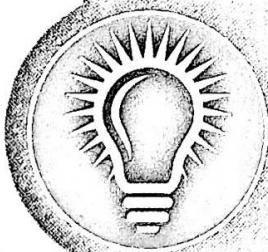
Checklist – elements to cover

- Creating the right atmosphere for the visit. Winning the customers trust
- Agree on the common objective of the visit – what are we going to achieve today?
- Agree on the agenda for the visit – how are we going to reach our common objective together?
- For visits to new customers/prospects: Presentation/ positioning of your value proposition and company
- Bridging into the next phase

Best Practice Execution

Creating the right atmosphere for the visit.

The perception of you as a sales professional can be seen as a 'trust account' you hold with the customer. All your actions will either add to the account's value or deduct from it (in case of bad customer experiences). You open your trust account the first time you meet the customer.



The Trustworthiness Equation:

$$\text{Trustworthiness} = \frac{\text{Credibility} + \text{Reliability} + \text{Intimacy}}{\text{Self-orientation}}$$

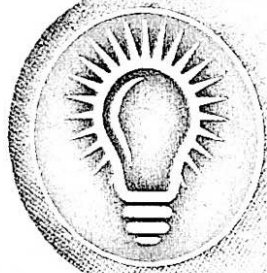
(Ref.: The Trusted Advisor)



How to reach the acceptance ... ?

" ... and then we conclude the meeting with a summary of what we have agreed to.

Would that be OK with you?"



The customer's ability to focus is strongest at the beginning of the visit.

Always begin with topics that require the most attention.

Every visits need to start with a social connection, small talk and setting the scene for the meeting.

After this you can distribute the topics as they fit your objective.

As a rule of thumb, always focus on customer's needs before presenting a solution.



Agenda examples for visiting an existing customer

- Since last visit
- Current situation
- Product Presentation
- Business Case
- Conclusion & Next step



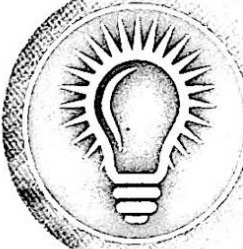
Agenda examples for visiting a new customer

- Presentation of your company
- Presentation of "Smith Hearing"
- Current Situation & Future wishes
- Possible areas for co-operation
- Conclusion & Next Steps

Bridging forward to the Needs Discovery phase

After the customer's acceptance of the meeting objective and agenda, the next natural thing to do is to engage in needs discovery.

What has happened since the last visit or what is the situation right now in the company?



Some sales professionals question why you start with presenting your company and not the prospect first. The WDH presentation is all about creating TRUST so you have an easier Needs Discovery Phase and the prospect allows you to ask challenging questions.

If you visit a new customer/prospect, the first thing you do after the acceptance of meeting objective and agenda is to present your company. As you do this, start to ask questions to get the prospect's attitude to some of the key messages in the presentation. This will give you an elegant bridge into the Needs Discovery Phase.

SALES VISIT:

Needs Discovery

Purpose

The purpose of the needs discovery phase is to discover the customer's situation, business, goals and needs.

Checklist – elements to cover

- Areas of needs discovery
- Needs, both factual and emotional areas
- Questioning technique
- From benefits to needs
- Active listening skills
- SHOW - A strong Needs Discovery Model

Best Practice Execution

Areas of Needs Discovery

We can address needs on so many levels.

Practical needs in terms of patient well-being, audiology, instrument capabilities for example.

Business needs in terms of gross profit requirements, units dispensed in a given time, instrument price points for example.

Personal, emotional and motivational needs in terms of ambition, desire for success, personal business vision of the customer for example.

It is important to remember that we should not only engage in a need discovery phase that focuses on our products. Although products are of interest to the customer, they are also very interested in how developing a good business partnership with you and WDH can help them realise personal and professional ambitions. What can working with your business do for his patients, his practice, his business and even his family?

Needs Discovery should focus on the following areas:

- The situation of the practice and the business
- Goals, wishes and dreams of the future
- The patients/clients in his practice
- How the customer and WDH can improve their partnership

Needs, both factual and emotional

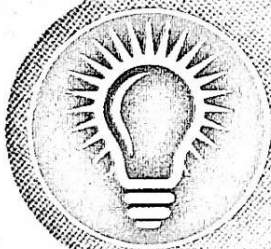
When discovering the needs of the customer, it is often useful to focus on discovering different levels of needs.

Factual needs are the needs that can relate to something material.

The customer needs a hearing instrument partner who can deliver products and service, which satisfies the customer and the customer's clients.

Emotional needs are the needs that customers feel. It could for example be the preference towards a brand, a person (sales rep), and the need of being seen and heard as a customer of you and WDH. It could also be to do with their professional and personal feelings about being in business, why they are in business, and what they feel a successful business looks like.

The question is of course whether the customer makes decisions based on facts or feelings – or perhaps even more precisely a mix between the two of them.



Studies show that people make decisions based on a mix between facts and emotions.

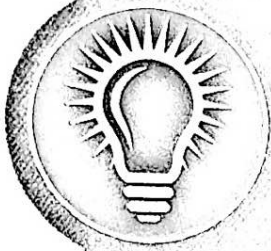
However, factual needs are easier to discover as they are normally evident in a reply to one of the sales rep's questions.

Emotional needs can be discovered by reading between the lines. What is not said, what does the body language tell you.

Questioning technique

A good questioning technique will most certainly help in discovering all types of needs, and it is a skilful art that most sales reps across the world would like to improve on.

Questions can be divided into two categories. Open questions and closed questions.



Open questions start with **What, How, Where, When, Who, Which, Why.**

Who do you see as the preferred premium partner in your business?

They are excellent to discover needs with.

Closed questions lead to a **Yes/No** reply or a choice between two or more options.

Are you satisfied with this model?

They are excellent for gaining acceptance/confirmation.

To have an efficient needs discovery, the sales rep needs to use both open and closed questions.

The open questions we use to discover needs, the closed questions we use to gain acceptance or to get confirmation.

An example.

SR: *How is your business doing these days?*

C: *It is doing relatively well. We are getting by.*

SR: *This sounds good. How do you see the difference between doing relatively well and doing extremely well?*

C: *Good question, I guess we would like to have 10-15% more clients coming through our door.*

SR: *What do you see as the primary obstacles for this?*

C: *We have cut back on advertisement the last year because of cash flow issues – so a focus on advertising would do the trick for us.*

SR: *Ok, so you believe an investment in advertisement would create an impact with 10-15% more clients through your door?*

C: *Yes.*

Going further – exploring emotional needs

It is also possible to use a subset of open questions to explore emotional and motivational needs, helping the customer to actually visualise what it would look like, and how he would feel if he did manage to get 10-15% more clients through the door.

These are called Ascending Questions, and are directed towards the feelings and motivation of the customer.

SR: *What would it mean to you and your business if you were to get 10-15% more clients through your door?*

C: *Well I would undoubtedly have an increase in dispensing rate and therefore revenue.*

SR: *Great, so how would you feel about that?*

C: *It would feel fantastic, and would be very useful at the moment*

SR: *In what way? Tell me more.*

C: *My eldest daughter is about to go to university so any extra income would help enormously.*

SR: *So how would you feel if together we could find a way to increase the footfall through the practice and help support your ambitions?*

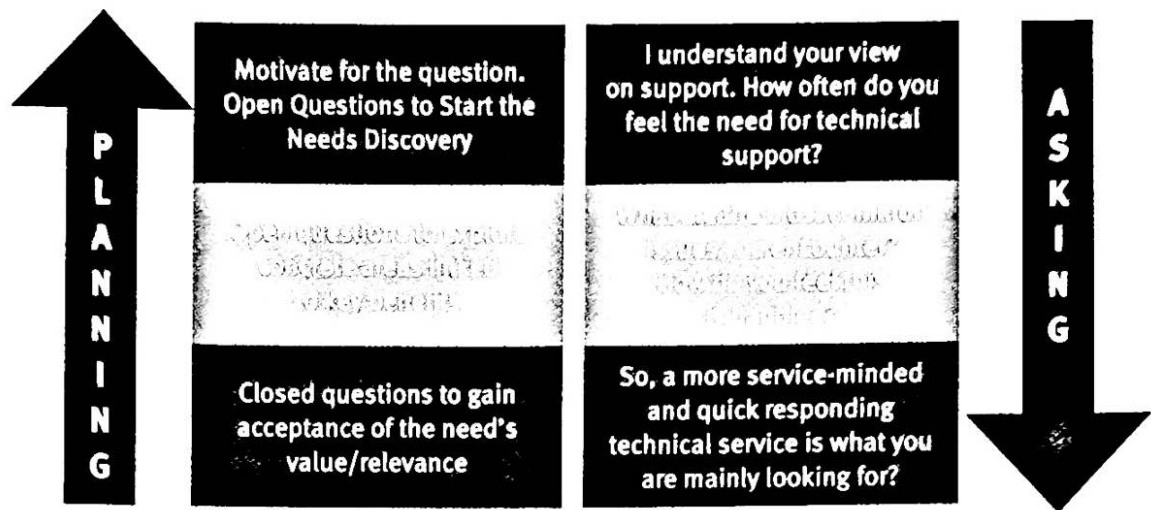
By using open Ascending Questions in the needs discovery phase we not only discover what the business ambitions might be, but what that would mean to the client personally. Once he/she can visualise this, it is a very powerful motivator to work more closely in the future.

From Benefits to Needs?

The use of open-ended questions and closed questions gives you a chance to steer the sales conversation in the direction you want. But where do you want to go?

Well, you will need to steer the conversation towards agreements that would benefit your case; **The Key Benefits** of the offer you want “to sell” to the customer. The offer could be an idea, it could be a concrete sales pitch – it does not matter – the process is the same.

Needs Discovery



As shown in the example, we plan based on which key benefits we would like to end up discussing the value of – so we plan from the bottom and we perform our asking, of course from the top.

Active listening skills

If the needs discovery phase is vital to the success of the sales rep, then the information we gather will be paramount in our efforts to position the best solution to the customer and win the opportunity.

It is really important therefore, that we use all our efforts to fully understand what the customer says, and we **Actively listen** intently to what they say.

Show interest in what the customer is saying. Not being present will discourage the customer from sharing vital information with you.

Be careful not to be distracted or to focus your attention on what you want to say next while the customer is answering your last question.

Be completely there in the moment.

Nod, tilt your head slightly so as to encourage the customer to continue to share more information with you. Do not interrupt because you think you have heard enough.

Ask for clarification when you hear abbreviations or words you do not know. The customer will only see this as interest and presence.

Check that you have understood the customer correctly by rephrasing what he said and gaining acceptance you have understood. Remember, you process the incoming information based on your own views and not the views of the customer – so check you understood correctly.

Look at body language. Much of our perception when listening comes from the body language of the person we are listening to. The customer will show signs about how he feels in his body language, without being able to fully control it. Eyes, arms, legs, posture, etc. Make sure you listen to 'everything', not just the words.

SALES VISIT: Presentation

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Purpose

The purpose of the presentation phase is to present solutions in alignment with the customer's expressed interests, concerns, needs and desires, as well as to agree next steps.

Checklist – elements to cover

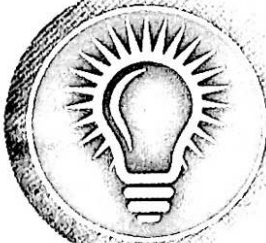
- Features tell – benefits sell
- How to present solutions with focus on needs & benefits
- Proving the benefits of your solution
- How to present price

Best Practice Execution

Features tell – benefits sell

The customer is buying what your solutions do for him NOT what your solution is.

Therefore it is vital you focus on the benefits your solution offers to the customer.



A benefit is only relevant to a customer if it fulfils a confirmed need of the customer.

Feature = 24/7 technical service hotline.

Benefit = reduced downtime on patients' defective hearing instruments which will increase patients' satisfaction & loyalty.

How to present solutions with focus on needs & benefits

To make the value of your solution absolutely clear to the customer you need to make the link between need, feature and benefit in a logical way.

- Start with stating the customer's need(s) and gain confirmation this is still a vital need
- Link the solution's feature(s) to the need(s)
- Link the benefit to the feature
- Gain acceptance that the customer sees the links

Proving the benefits of your solution

In many cases, your word will not be enough to make the customer change behaviour or make a buying decision. This especially happens when you have not yet established a very strong and trustworthy relationship.

Always assume your solution needs some kind of proof.

In this case you need to support your benefit presentation with proof. That could be:

- Business Case
- Reference from another (trustworthy) customer
- Study or analysis
- Return on investment calculations
- Demonstration of a product

Always check whether the customer accepts your proof.

Presenting price

When presenting the cost of your solution the customer is considering what he/she gets for his money. Does he get a higher return than the actual cost?

We have every motive to let the price seem as little as possible compared with the return of investment the customer achieves.

There are some techniques that support this.

Investment. Always use the word investment when mentioning the price. It has a psychological effect on the customer. Investment indicates a return or a win as a consequence of the investment.

Sandwich method. When presenting price make sure you present benefits before and after stating the price. Price is the filling, benefits are the bread.

Example:

The key benefits of our solution are a premium product range which offers your customers best-in-class hearing instruments.

The investment is only €4,000 per set and in addition to this you gain access to our extended technical service hotline that subsequently will reduce your handling time by 40%.

Quantify the price. Divide the price into smaller pieces.

Example: So, for only €5 extra per day you will receive the ...

Do not be afraid ... if you have discovered the needs of the customer and linked the benefits of your solution in a professional way, there is no reason why you would get an objection on price.

SALES VISIT: Overcoming Objections

**SALES VIS
Closing**

Purpose

The purpose of overcoming objections is to be able to move beyond a spoken or unspoken objection in a professional manner and continue the sales visit towards your goal.

Checklist – elements to cover

- What is an objection
- Analysing the cause of the objection
- Overcoming the objection

Best Practice Execution

What is an objection?

First of all, relax, an objection is often a clear signal of an intention to buy or to accept your suggestions, so use this to strengthen your confidence to move on – it is more dangerous if the customer says nothing to your suggestions – does he really care then?

- An objection is when the customer communicates there is something he does not understand
- An objection is when the customer disagrees with you

Analysing the cause of the objection.

You cannot handle an objection before you understand what lies behind the objection – what is the reason.

So, the first thing you need to do when faced with an objection is to explore the reason for it. You do this by asking open-ended questions and listening to what the customer replies ... and what is not said – read between the lines.

Handling objections

There are many ways to handle objections. It is most important to prepare for the objections you think you may meet during the sales visit.

As mentioned above, you need to uncover the real reason for the objection. Therefore the main tool to handle objections is to use questions and understand exactly what the customer means before handling the objection.

For this purpose, you use the AQST-model.

A – Acknowledge (neutral – does not mean you agree or disagree)

Q – Question to Clarify

S – Support (with relevant data to overcome concern)

T – Transition to bigger picture

Example:

C: I do not think the new product "X" will work with my patients – I think I will stay with the old version "Y".

SR: (A) OK, I understand you have worries about "X".

SR: (Q) What are your main concerns?

C: I cannot see it is a better product and it is so much more expensive.

SR: (Q) Besides the price of "X", do you have any other concerns?

C: No – that is the main thing.

SR: (S) I understand. Yes, "X" is more expensive than "Y", that is true. But when you take into account the new spatial sound advancements and the improved sense of direction of sound for the patients, wouldn't you think a lot would be willing to pay slightly more to have this improvement?

C: Well, I guess some would.

SR: (T) I believe you are right. Could we agree to you testing "X" on 2-3 patients over the next month and you can get feedback – would that be ok?

C: Yes – ok, let's try that.

SR: Great, I will come back to you tomorrow to organise it.

Other methods to handle objections

The acknowledgement

It is always important to acknowledge the objection. It is a bit like giving a customer a verbal receipt for what they have said, and proves you have been actively listening.

C: I don't think your customer support is working very well.

SR: In what way? (Customer elaborates)

SR: (Listens intently) Yes, I agree, you have experienced some challenges over the last months and I admit this is below par. And when you remember our performance the last weeks I hope you feel we have worked hard to gain your trust again – would you agree?

C: I admit it has become better.

Anticipating uncertainty

(Important, you need to be 100% sure the customer will make this objection or we are creating an objection we did not have to.)

This is used to simply lay out any objections that the customer is very likely thinking but not saying. It is important to get the objection discussed because even if they were not thinking of it at the time, it is likely it will come up after you have gone.

SR: Most of my clients at this stage have the thought that the higher price of "X" would be difficult to justify. Are you thinking the same?

C: Yes I was actually.

SR: I understand your concern, "X" is more expensive than "Y", and when you take into account the new spatial sound advancements and the improved sense of direction of sound, most of my clients find their patients are very happy to pay extra.

OR

SR: It is quite common at this stage to be thinking that selling more high-end instruments would be great if only I had more of the patient demographic that spent that type of money. Has that crossed your mind?

C: It hadn't but I do see your point.

SR: Yes, it is a common concern. What we have to do between us is to consider how we can support you to increase the footfall of such patients through your practice. How does that sound?

C: Ok, that sounds great.

Isolate the objection

(Used when you need to make sure the customer has exhausted his objections – very efficient near deal closure)

C: I am not happy about the payment terms – I want 2 months.

SR: (isolate the objection): Besides the payment terms, are there any other concerns we need to address before we agree?

C: Well, no – this is my only concern.

SR: Great, so if we can reach an agreement on payment terms, we can finalise our agreement?

C: Yes, we can.

Feel, Felt, Solved

To be used when facing an objection that you have had before and successfully solved. This principle works on the premise that human's like to feel as if they are not alone and other people have felt the same way as them.

Customer gives you an objection – for example:

C: I am concerned about putting such high-end instruments into stock in case they have an impact on my cash flow.

*SR: I understand how you **FEEL** Mr. Smith, I had another customer only last week who also **FELT** exactly the same as you.*

*How we **SOLVED** it for him was to extend his credit terms by 30 days for the three trial pairs he put into stock, which gave him plenty of time to trial fit them on his targeted patients without affecting his cash flow. The outcome was he sold all three instruments before he even had to pay for them. Would you like us to do the same for you?*

Feel, Felt, Solved will work for a number of sales objections. You just have to try a few out and practice!

SALES VISIT: **Closing**

Purpose

The purpose of the closing phase is to help the customer move towards making a decision.

Checklist – elements to cover

- Summary and agreement
- Ask for the business – Closing the easy way
- Closing techniques

Best Practice Execution

Summary and agreement

At this phase of the sales visit we are close to the end – we just need to wrap it up.

In order for you to make sure you close the sales visit on the same page as the customer, make a summary of the agreements made and ask the customer yet again for commitment towards your common understanding of those agreements.

For sales visits that do not end up with a deal but are visits with a different purpose, ask the customer whether he feels you reached the agreed objectives.

Ask for the business – closing done the easy way

You have come this far in the meeting. You are going to “pop the question” soon about whether you have a deal with the customer.

Before you do, let us recap on what you have done so far:

- You have discovered the needs of the customer
- You have allowed him to visualise the desired future state by asking good Ascending Questions
- You have presented the features and benefits – and linked these to the customer's needs
- You have handled objections successfully

If you have done all this with good quality – the question is easy to pose. The customer is already convinced.

So, can we move forward with this deal?

If you get an unexpected NO here, the way forward is to try to understand the reason behind the NO and to isolate the reasons.

SR: So, are you ready to make a commitment?

C: No, not at this point.

SR: OK, what is holding you back?

C: I need to align with my accountant before the decision can be made.

SR: Sure, no problem. Are there any other reasons for not committing at this point in time?

C: No, this is the only one.

SR: OK, so when you have aligned with your accountant you can commit to the project?

C: Yes.

Closing techniques

There are a couple of closing techniques the sales rep can use to help the process. But there is no magic dust to spray over the customer and if he out of the blue says YES, the customer has already decided.

The alternative method

You offer the customer two equal options that both serve the same purpose, to close the deal. The idea is to make sure the question cannot be answered with a YES or a NO.

SR: So, would you prefer the first shipment to arrive this week or to arrive next week?

Shall I order you two sets of instruments or would you like to have the wrap offer of three?

Taking sales for granted

It will test your customer's commitment during the sales visit and boost your own confidence if you choose to use the word "when" and not "if" when you talk about a future cooperation.

Applying some gentle pressure

Often our customers just need reassurance. Once you have isolated the objection and handled it successfully, it can seem very strange that on occasions they still don't seem ready to commit.

The technique of 'gentle pressure' can often work as follows:

SR: So, Mr. Smith, are you ready to move forward and order?

C: Well, I am still not completely sure I want to do that just now.

SR: OK, so let me check, you are completely happy with everything we discussed?

C: Yes.

SR: And you see the benefits to your business and your clients?

C: Yes.

SR: And we have discussed this three times already haven't we?

C: Yes.

SR: Mr. Smith, can I ask you one more question. Do you have trust in me?

C: Yes.

SR: So shall I send the two instruments in for the end of this week or early next week?

It does not matter what you are trying to get commitment to.

This technique is very useful when there is a good relationship and you have answered all the clients' questions and objections.

They just need a little help in being persuaded to take the action required to move forward.

SALES VISIT: Post-Visit

Purpose

The purpose of the post-visit phase is to ensure the customer experiences a professional follow-up to the meeting and a bridge is made towards the next meeting.

Checklist – elements to cover

- Your own evaluation
- Commit in writing within 24 hrs
- CRM update within 48 hrs

Best Practice Execution

Your own evaluation

Time for reflection – did you meet the SMART objectives you set for the visit?

- Why (yes) or why (not)?
- Which consequences does the outcome of the visit have for your overall plan for the account?
- What is the next step for the account? When?
- What did you succeed with?
- What could you have done better?

Commit in writing within 24 hrs

Committing to the customer in writing is part of a professional sales process. Done in a timely manner within 24 hrs it leaves the customer with the feeling of being an important partner of you and our company.

These days, comprehensive minutes or records do not work anymore. You need to be short, precise and to the point.

The minutes should reflect the decisions made and confirm any agreements made.

CRM update within 48 hrs

Any activity conducted needs to be updated in the CRM system in order to make sure you keep track of the updates on your account. Attach any documents you have forwarded to the customer and make notes about this visit and the SMART objective for the next visit.